

I wish more women would heed this advice. I think it's a tragedy that so many married women—even those with very successful careers—shy away from the family finances. Independent agency Maddock Douglas recently surveyed over 600 women ages 21 to 59. *Ninety percent* of these women weren't sure how much money to invest or what type of investment accounts to open, and 84 percent lacked faith in their ability to set and meet specific financial benchmarks.

If you're a woman reading this book, please: break the trend! You don't have to go it alone—that's why you team up with a really good investment advisor who can steer you in the right direction. I'm here to tell you that you not only *can* do it, you must. I've said before that I believe women make better investors than men, and I stand by that. They tend to be more conservative than men—they're less risk-oriented. Women often have the ability to step back and take a more comprehensive and nuanced view. And yet, so often they are put in a position where they don't control the family's finances. That's a huge mistake.

Ladies, you are not hurting your marriage by having your own accounts and advisors or by being money-conscious; you're actually helping it. There's no need to be clandestine. Tell your partner what you're doing and why. All you're doing is forcing diversification. Trust me: that's a good thing.

Once you're ready to work with a financial advisor, you'll need to decide whether to hire a planner or a broker. These aren't synonymous—they actually do two different things. Planners can help you with life insurance and tax savings, but as far as investments go, they can buy only mutual funds, whereas a broker can buy stocks and bonds. The Mutual Fund Dealers Association of Canada (MFDA) regulates planners; brokers are regulated by the Investment Industry Regulatory Organization of Canada (IIROC). Each has specialized knowledge: planners can help you with life insurance and tax planning, whereas brokers focus more on trading stocks and creating an investment portfolio. All banks have brokerage arms; they do not have planner arms.